

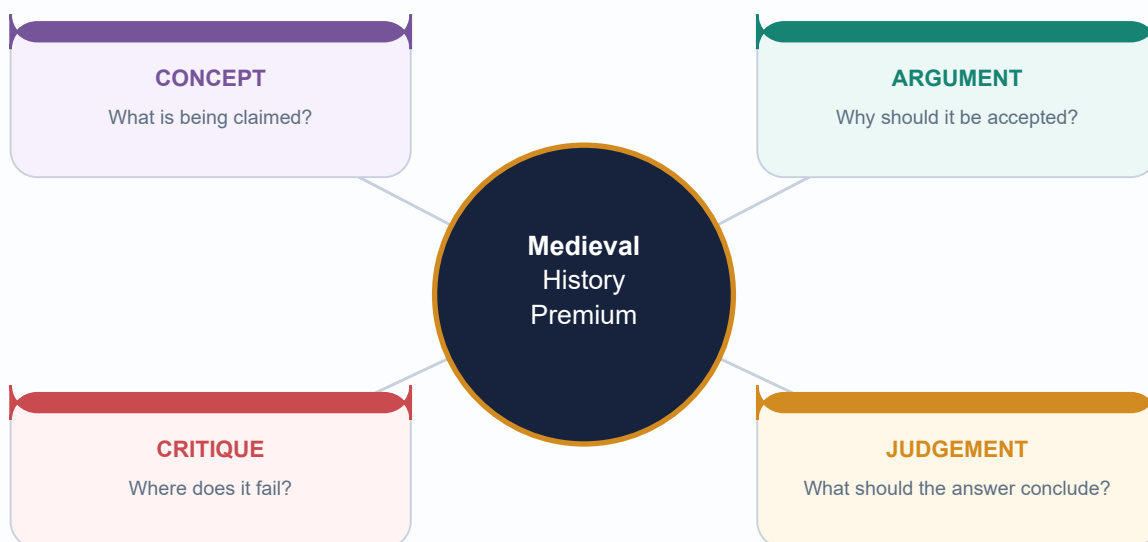
SOLVED WORKBOOK | APPROVED=FALSE

Medieval History 02 - Premium Solved Practice Workbook

The Ghaznavids & the Ghurian Invasions

Strict A -> B -> C -> D answer rotation across all 60 MCQs

Generated 13 August 2026 | Approval pending (yellow)



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

Package Scope, Evidence Discipline and Approval State

Prelims + GS-I
Medieval History

PACKAGE STATE

Complete learning session + solved workbook + reusable Markdown. Generated with approved=false; only explicit user approval can change the state.

PRACTICE AND STRUCTURE COUNTS

Component	Count
Verified/routed PYQs	3
Hard MCQs	48
Remedial MCQs	12
Solved 10/15/20 Mains	3 each
Final register modules	15, placed last

EVIDENCE RULES

- FACT is separated from textual report, material evidence, interpretation, inference and limit.
- Mahmud of Ghazni, Muizz al-Din Muhammad bin Sam and Qutb al-Din Aibak are never collapsed.
- Campaign totals, army numbers, motives and temple narratives are treated as source-dependent where appropriate.
- Every solved Mains answer uses claim -> named evidence -> significance -> qualification and ends with Why this earns marks.

DELIVERABLES

1. Main PDF contains all teaching and practice, ending with topic-specific register notes.
2. Workbook contains the verified PYQ, 60 MCQs and nine solved Mains answers.
3. Reusable Markdown is the complete content master.

APPROVAL CHECKS

WRONG: Generated means approved.

CORRECT: The state remains approved=false until explicit user approval.

WRONG: A court chronicle's report is automatically a fact.

CORRECT: Genre, patronage, chronology and corroboration are always stated.

ANSWER STANDARD

Demand -> direct thesis -> claim -> named source/site/battle/coin -> significance -> limit -> graded verdict.

SOURCE ORDER

Repository Markdown -> OCR books -> bounded authoritative links; Qdrant not used.

HIGH

Sources Actually Used and Bounded Linkages

Prelims + GS-I
Source Method

KEY DATA

Source layer	Exact base	Use / caveat
Repository	Topic 02 basic/advanced; chronology; revision; routing; bounded 01/03/07/11	Controls sequence, boundaries and answer architecture.
Local concise book	Satish Chandra, printed pp. 58-76; PDF pp. 69-87	Campaigns, Rajput states, conquest and causal debate.
Local advanced book	Satish Chandra Part I, printed pp. 14-33; PDF pp. 8-17	Samanids, military slavery, roads, iqta, source differences and strategy.
Named traditions	al-Utbi, al-Biruni, Gardizi, Bayhaqi, Hasan Nizami, Minhaj, Indic texts, coins	Report and limit are separated; no fabricated quote.
Authoritative live	UNESCO Jam/Qutb; WMF Ghazni; LOC; UPenn; Cambridge JRAS	Heritage/source link only; no decorative current affairs.

STATIC THEORY

- UNESCO Jam: <https://whc.unesco.org/en/list/211>
- UNESCO Qutb: <https://whc.unesco.org/en/list/233/>
- World Monuments Fund Ghazni: <https://www.wmf.org/monuments/ghazni-minarets>
- Library of Congress Kitab-i-Yamini: <https://www.loc.gov/item/52053674/>
- UPenn Tabaqat re-reading: <https://repository.upenn.edu/entities/publication/85ed44bd-a551-4a68-8163-13e2c81891a3>
- Cambridge JRAS Somnath memory study: A7809AEE9FC17740CD76CA0239CD6048

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. No useful 2025-26 current-affairs item was forced.
2. The official 2022 Prelims key is unavailable locally; the answer is visibly labelled inferred.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: A heritage description replaces medieval source criticism.

CORRECT: Heritage pages support monuments and conservation only.

MAINS ANGLE

Triangulate chronicle, material evidence and later memory.

STUDY LINK

Complete source list is preserved in the reusable Markdown.

HIGH

PYQ 01 - 2022 Prelims GS-I Q96: Somnath Temple and al-Biruni

Prelims 2022
Verified PYQ

OFFICIAL QUESTION ROUTE

The Prime Minister recently inaugurated the new Circuit House near Somnath Temple at Veraval. Which of the following statements are correct regarding Somnath Temple? (1) Somnath Temple is one of the Jyotirlinga shrines. (2) A description of Somnath Temple was given by Al-Biruni. (3) Pran Pratishtha of Somnath Temple (installation of the present day temple) was done by President S. Radhakrishnan.

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	1 and 2 only
B	2 and 3 only
C	1 and 3 only
D	1, 2 and 3

MODEL SOLUTION

- Answer: A - 1 and 2 only (INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED; high confidence).
- Statement 1 is correct: Somnath is one of the twelve Jyotirlinga shrines.
- Statement 2 is correct: al-Biruni's writing includes a description relevant to Somnath.
- Statement 3 is incorrect: the consecration of the reconstructed present temple in 1951 was performed by President Rajendra Prasad, not S. Radhakrishnan.
- TOPIC LINK: The question tests al-Biruni as a source and modern Somnath memory, not only temple chronology.
- LIMIT: The answer does not validate every later narrative about Mahmud's 1025 raid.

KEY STATUS

1. Question wording is verified through repository routing and matching published transcriptions.
2. No narrowly battle-specific GS Mains PYQ was found in the bounded repository set; none was fabricated.

SOURCE CAUTION

WRONG: Treat the inferred key as an official UPSC key.

CORRECT: The PDF labels it INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED.

WHY THIS EARNS MARKS

It tests each statement independently, gives the key-status warning, links the fact to source criticism and avoids importing contested raid details.

PYQ STATUS

Question wording verified through the repository's 2022 routing and matching published paper transcriptions. The official key is unavailable in the local repository; answer is labelled inferred.

HIGH

PYQ 02 - 2018 GS-I Mains: Chinese and Arab travellers

GS-I Verified
PYQ

OFFICIAL QUESTION AND DIRECTIVE

Assess the importance of the accounts of the Chinese and Arab travellers in the reconstruction of the history of India. (10 marks, 150 words)

EVIDENCE-LED MODEL ANSWER

- Direct thesis: Chinese and Arab accounts are indispensable external witnesses when their itinerary, genre, language and audience are tested against Indian texts, inscriptions, coins and archaeology.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Xuanzang's seventh-century pilgrimage record describes Harsha's political world, Nalanda and Buddhist geography.
- It reconstructs institutions and routes, but a Buddhist pilgrim naturally magnified monasteries and sacred centres.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Sulaiman and al-Masudi noticed major Indian powers, ports and commerce connected with the Persian Gulf.
- They prove India's wide political and trading reputation, though some information circulated through merchants rather than direct observation.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Al-Biruni's Kitab al-Hind used Sanskrit learning to compare religion, astronomy, calendars and social classification.
- Its analytical precision is exceptional, yet Brahmanical textual access and a north-western setting narrow its social reach.
- Conclusion: These travellers are therefore high-value comparative and corroborative sources, not neutral photographs of all-India conditions.

ANSWER CHECKLIST

1. The answer fulfils the directive rather than merely listing sources.
2. Each named source is linked to what it reconstructs and what limits it.
3. The conclusion gives a graded judgement about representative value.

SOURCE CAUTION

WRONG: Narrate authors without assessing genre, patronage or social reach.

CORRECT: Use source -> contribution -> limitation -> corroborated verdict.

WHY THIS EARNS MARKS

It fulfils 'assess', compares three named source clusters, explains what each reconstructs, supplies a limitation for each and ends with a graded corroboration-based judgement.

ROUTING STATUS

Official GS-I question verified in the repository's revised Medieval Topic 01 package; routed here because al-Biruni is a core Topic 02 source.

HIGH**PYQ 03 - 2020 GS-I Mains: Persian literary sources**GS-I Verified
PYQ**OFFICIAL QUESTION AND DIRECTIVE**

Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment. (15 marks, 250 words)

EVIDENCE-LED MODEL ANSWER

- Direct thesis: Persian works reflect medieval political ideals, conquest, administration, dissent and social worlds, but their 'spirit of the age' becomes representative only through comparison across genres and non-court evidence.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: al-Utbi's ornate Kitab al-Yamini celebrates Sabuktigin and Mahmud and reveals Ghaznavid legitimacy, ghazi language and court ambition.
- Panegyric, weak Indian geography and its pre-Somnath end limit literal use.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Hasan Nizami's Taj al-Ma'asir and Minhaj-us-Siraj's Tabaqat-i Nasiri record conquest, vassalage, Ghurid genealogy and early Sultanate succession.
- Court patronage, chronological distance and elite focus shape their selection.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Barani's Tarikh-i Firoz Shahi and normative Fatawa-i Jahandari expose Sultanate politics and aristocratic-orthodox ideals.
- His didactic hierarchy cannot represent all society.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Abul Fazl's Akbarnama and Ain-i Akbari display Mughal sovereignty and bureaucratic classification, while Badauni preserves conservative dissent.
- Both are court-centred and partisan in different directions.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Amir Khusrau's panegyric and the Sufi conversations of Fawa'id-ul-Fu'ad widen the archive toward literary encounter and khanqah life, yet remain mediated compositions.
- Conclusion: Persian literature reflects several competing 'spirits' - royal, clerical, administrative, poetic and devotional - rather than one transparent age.

ANSWER CHECKLIST

1. The answer fulfils the directive rather than merely listing sources.
2. Each named source is linked to what it reconstructs and what limits it.
3. The conclusion gives a graded judgement about representative value.

SOURCE CAUTION

WRONG: Narrate authors without assessing genre, patronage or social reach.

CORRECT: Use source -> contribution -> limitation -> corroborated verdict.

WHY THIS EARNS MARKS

It comments rather than lists, spans early Ghaznavid/Ghurid to Sultanate/Mughal genres, links six named evidence clusters to social reach and patronage limits, and gives a qualified verdict.

ROUTING STATUS

Official GS-I question verified in the repository's revised Medieval Topic 01 package; routed here through the Topic 02 and Topic 07 Persian-source banks.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 01****Prelims Solved
Practice****QUESTION**

Which statement best distinguishes the three political phases?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	Mahmud's Ghaznavids held Punjab but did not found the Delhi Sultanate; Muizz al-Din's Ghurids opened wider conquest; post-1206 rulers consolidated an Indian-centred Sultanate.
B	Mahmud and Muizz al-Din were titles of one ruler.
C	The Ghurids were a branch of the Delhi Sultanate created by Iltutmish.
D	Aibak ruled independently before Tarain.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: A - Mahmud's Ghaznavids held Punjab but did not found the Delhi Sultanate; Muizz al-Din's Ghurids opened wider conquest; post-1206 rulers consolidated an Indian-centred Sultanate.
- Explanation: Dynasty, objective and chronology must be separated.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH

Hard MCQ 02

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

What best explains the Samanid connection to Ghaznavid rise?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	The Samanids were a Rajput dynasty ruling Lahore.
B	The Samanid military-political order employed Turkic commanders within a Persianate court world.
C	The Samanids abolished military slavery throughout Central Asia.
D	The Samanids conquered Delhi in the tenth century.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: B - The Samanid military-political order employed Turkic commanders within a Persianate court world.
- Explanation: Alp-tigin's career grew from this mixed Persianate-Turkic setting.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH**Hard MCQ 03**

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Which is the safest reading of frontier geography?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	The Khyber alone made conquest inevitable.
B	Mountains permanently sealed India from Central Asia.
C	Routes became militarily effective only when combined with bases, roads, logistics, intelligence and political opportunity.
D	Every army used one identical route.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: C - Routes became militarily effective only when combined with bases, roads, logistics, intelligence and political opportunity.

- Explanation: Geography enabled and constrained; it did not decide outcomes by itself.

- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH

Hard MCQ 04

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Why is military slavery historically significant here?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	It meant all cavalymen were chattel with no political agency.
B	It was unique to India and unknown in West Asia.
C	It eliminated succession conflict.
D	It created trained service commanders dependent on rulers, though such commanders could later found their own powers.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: D - It created trained service commanders dependent on rulers, though such commanders could later found their own powers.
- Explanation: Aibak's career shows both dependence and mobility.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH

Hard MCQ 05

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Which source is a panegyric court narrative of early Ghaznavid campaigns?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	al-Utbi's Kitab al-Yamini.
B	al-Biruni's Kitab al-Hind.
C	Prithviraj Raso.
D	Tabaqat-i Nasiri.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: A - al-Utbi's Kitab al-Yamini.
- Explanation: al-Utbi is valuable but shaped by courtly victory rhetoric.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH**Hard MCQ 06**

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Which source-method statement is correct?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	Contemporary sources need no corroboration.
B	A source's date, genre, patron and distance from the event must be established before using its report.
C	Inscriptions always provide complete social history.
D	Later chronicles are worthless by definition.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: B - A source's date, genre, patron and distance from the event must be established before using its report.
- Explanation: Source criticism ranks and cross-checks rather than automatically accepting or rejecting.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH

Hard MCQ 07

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Why can al-Utbi not serve as the direct account of Somnath 1025?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	He wrote only in Sanskrit.
B	He lived in the sixteenth century.
C	His narrative closes before that campaign.
D	He was a Gahadavala court poet.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: C - His narrative closes before that campaign.
- Explanation: Chronology is the first source check.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH

Hard MCQ 08

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

What is the principal limit of Prithviraj Raso for Tarain?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	It contains no mention of Prithviraj.
B	It is an Arabic Ghaznavid fiscal manual.
C	It is a securely dated 1192 inscription.
D	It is a layered later literary tradition, not a contemporary battle report.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: D - It is a layered later literary tradition, not a contemporary battle report.
- Explanation: It is valuable for memory, not unfiltered chronology.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH**Hard MCQ 09**

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Which sequence is correct?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	Alp-tigin at Ghazni -> Sabuktigin -> Mahmud.
B	Mahmud -> Alp-tigin -> Sabuktigin.
C	Sabuktigin -> Muizz al-Din -> Alp-tigin.
D	Jayapala -> Alp-tigin -> Mahmud.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: A - Alp-tigin at Ghazni -> Sabuktigin -> Mahmud.
- Explanation: This is the basic Ghaznavid rise sequence.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH

Hard MCQ 10

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

What does the Hindu Shahi resistance demonstrate?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	The Shahis surrendered without battle.
B	The frontier struggle was prolonged and included offensive coalitions, battles, forts and setbacks.
C	All Rajput states fought under one permanent command.
D	The Shahis defeated Mahmud permanently in 1001.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: B - The frontier struggle was prolonged and included offensive coalitions, battles, forts and setbacks.
- Explanation: Jayapala and Anandapala complicate passive-collapse narratives.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH

Hard MCQ 11

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

How should the 'seventeen invasions' formula be treated?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	As a precisely audited contemporary number.
B	As proof that all campaigns had one motive.
C	As a conventional count whose total varies with the grouping of operations.
D	As a count of Ghurid battles after 1175.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: C - As a conventional count whose total varies with the grouping of operations.
- Explanation: Use key campaigns and a date range, not false precision.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH**Hard MCQ 12**

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Which was Mahmud's most durable Indian territorial result?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	Permanent annexation of Gujarat.
B	A Ghaznavid capital at Delhi.
C	Direct rule over Bengal.
D	Control in Punjab/Multan and the Lahore-linked frontier sphere.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: D - Control in Punjab/Multan and the Lahore-linked frontier sphere.
- Explanation: Operational reach into the plains exceeded administrative reach.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH

Hard MCQ 13

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

What does the 1018 Mathura-Kanauj campaign best illustrate?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	Deep rapid raiding could produce plunder and political shock without lasting annexation.
B	Ghaznavid settlement of the entire Ganga valley.
C	The end of all Pratihara and Gahadavala politics.
D	A Ghurid cavalry defeat.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: A - Deep rapid raiding could produce plunder and political shock without lasting annexation.
- Explanation: Raid and rule must be separated.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH

Hard MCQ 14

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Which is the best multi-causal thesis on Mahmud?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	Religion was the sole cause of every campaign.
B	Frontier strategy, political legitimacy, revenue, Central Asian wars and religious rhetoric interacted in changing proportions.
C	Only commercial trade explains the raids.
D	Mahmud had no political interest in Punjab.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: B - Frontier strategy, political legitimacy, revenue, Central Asian wars and religious rhetoric interacted in changing proportions.
- Explanation: A ranked synthesis outperforms single-cause answers.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH**Hard MCQ 15**

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Why were temples attractive campaign targets in some cases?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	They were the only places with wealth in India.
B	Every temple was attacked uniformly.
C	They could combine wealth, royal patronage, urban centrality and religious symbolism.
D	Their destruction automatically transferred land administration.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: C - They could combine wealth, royal patronage, urban centrality and religious symbolism.
- Explanation: Temple targeting requires contextual political economy.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH**Hard MCQ 16**

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

What evidence weakens a civilisation-war explanation of Ghaznavid armies?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	Mahmud never used religious rhetoric.
B	Ghaznavids avoided all conflict with Muslim rulers.
C	Punjab had no mixed population.
D	Hindu commanders and Jat soldiers served in Ghaznavid forces.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: D - Hindu commanders and Jat soldiers served in Ghaznavid forces.
- Explanation: Composite service networks coexisted with coercion and ideology.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH

Hard MCQ 17

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Which statement on Somnath sources is correct?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	Later Persian, Sanskrit, Jain, epigraphic and modern memory layers must be distinguished from early evidence.
B	al-Utbi personally witnessed the 1025 raid.
C	Prithviraj Raso is the primary Somnath source.
D	One source silence proves no disruption.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: A - Later Persian, Sanskrit, Jain, epigraphic and modern memory layers must be distinguished from early evidence.

- Explanation: The event and its memories form different evidentiary layers.

- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH

Hard MCQ 18

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Which statement best describes al-Biruni's method?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	Court panegyric devoted only to Mahmud's battles.
B	Comparative inquiry using Sanskrit learning across religion, science and social thought.
C	A later Rajput heroic poem.
D	A tax register of Lahore.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: B - Comparative inquiry using Sanskrit learning across religion, science and social thought.
- Explanation: Kitab al-Hind is analytical rather than a conquest chronicle.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH**Hard MCQ 19**

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

What is a major limit of al-Biruni's India account?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	He knew no Indian language.
B	He wrote before contact with India.
C	Its access is strongest to learned Brahmanical texts and north-western intellectual settings.
D	He provides a complete village census.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: C - Its access is strongest to learned Brahmanical texts and north-western intellectual settings.
- Explanation: Exceptional scholarship still had social and regional blind spots.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH

Hard MCQ 20

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

What does Persianate most accurately describe?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	Only ethnic Persian kings.
B	A religion separate from Islam.
C	A Rajput clan system.
D	A transregional Persian language, literary and administrative culture used by rulers of varied origins.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: D - A transregional Persian language, literary and administrative culture used by rulers of varied origins.
- Explanation: Ghaznavid Turkic rulers were major Persianate patrons.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH

Hard MCQ 21

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

What is the safest interpretation of Lahore's role?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	It became a territorial, cultural and logistical bridge between Ghaznavid, Ghurid and early Sultanate phases.
B	It remained irrelevant to Indian campaigns.
C	It was founded by Muizz al-Din after 1206.
D	It was the site of Tarain II.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: A - It became a territorial, cultural and logistical bridge between Ghaznavid, Ghurid and early Sultanate phases.
- Explanation: Lahore is the key continuity without dynastic collapse.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH**Hard MCQ 22**

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Which factor pushed the Ghurids toward India?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	A permanent alliance with the Khwarazmians.
B	A combination of rivalry with Ghaznavids, western pressure and opportunity through Punjab.
C	The absence of any interests in Ghazni.
D	A command from the Delhi Sultanate.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: B - A combination of rivalry with Ghaznavids, western pressure and opportunity through Punjab.
- Explanation: Constraint and opportunity interacted.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH

Hard MCQ 23

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

What was distinctive about Ghiyas al-Din and Muizz al-Din?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	They fought each other throughout their reigns.
B	They were both sons of Mahmud of Ghazni.
C	Their fraternal partnership divided western and eastern strategic labour.
D	They ruled only after 1206.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: C - Their fraternal partnership divided western and eastern strategic labour.
- Explanation: The partnership strengthened Ghurid reach.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH

Hard MCQ 24

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Why must early Ghur be studied critically?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	No source mentions Ghur.
B	It was always a major urban capital equal to Baghdad.
C	Archaeology proves every chronicle false.
D	Later dynastic sources can caricature its pre-imperial society and religion.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: D - Later dynastic sources can caricature its pre-imperial society and religion.
- Explanation: Read Tabaqat against the grain, not literally or dismissively.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH**Hard MCQ 25**

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Which sequence of Muizz al-Din's early campaigns is correct?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	Multan/Uch -> Gujarat setback -> Punjab/Lahore consolidation.
B	Tarain II -> Multan -> Gujarat.
C	Somnath -> Chandawar -> Lahore.
D	Delhi -> Ghazni -> Uch.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: A - Multan/Uch -> Gujarat setback -> Punjab/Lahore consolidation.
- Explanation: The sequence reveals strategic adaptation.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH

Hard MCQ 26

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

What was the chief lesson of the 1178 Gujarat defeat?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	Ghurid cavalry could never fight in India.
B	Long lines and prepared resistance required a shift toward a Punjab-first strategy.
C	Gujarat was immediately annexed the next year.
D	Muizz al-Din abandoned India permanently.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: B - Long lines and prepared resistance required a shift toward a Punjab-first strategy.
- Explanation: Defeat produced route and base revision.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH

Hard MCQ 27

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Which statement best explains Ghurid learning?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	He never lost a battle.
B	He relied on one unchanged desert route.
C	Muizz al-Din changed routes and preparation after defeats in Gujarat and Tarain I.
D	He withdrew from Punjab after 1186.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: C - Muizz al-Din changed routes and preparation after defeats in Gujarat and Tarain I.
- Explanation: Adaptation, not inherent superiority, is the key.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH**Hard MCQ 28**

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

What does Tarain I prove?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	Tarain I founded the Sultanate.
B	Jaichandra led the Ghurid army.
C	Mounted archery guaranteed Ghurid victory.
D	Rajput forces could defeat the Ghurids in open battle, rejecting inevitability.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: D - Rajput forces could defeat the Ghurids in open battle, rejecting inevitability.
- Explanation: 1191 is the essential counter-example.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH

Hard MCQ 29

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Which tactical description is associated with Tarain II in Satish Chandra?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	Mounted archers harassed slower forces through movement and attacks from multiple directions.
B	A purely naval battle.
C	Only infantry fought on both sides.
D	The Ghurids won without manoeuvre or reserves.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: A - Mounted archers harassed slower forces through movement and attacks from multiple directions.
- Explanation: Organisation and movement mattered more than one weapon.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH

Hard MCQ 30

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Why is the Sanyogita story unsafe as the main explanation for Jaichandra's absence?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	Jaichandra fought at Tarain for Muizz al-Din.
B	It is a later romance; political rivalry is better established than the abduction narrative.
C	The story appears in al-Utbi before 1020.
D	No rivalry existed between the dynasties.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: B - It is a later romance; political rivalry is better established than the abduction narrative.
- Explanation: Later memory cannot replace contemporary corroboration.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH**Hard MCQ 31**

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

What was the immediate political effect of Tarain II?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	It instantly created uniform rule from Gujarat to Bengal.
B	It restored Ghaznavid power.
C	It opened the Delhi-Ajmer zone to Ghurid occupation, vassalage and later direct control.
D	It ended every Chahamana line.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: C - It opened the Delhi-Ajmer zone to Ghurid occupation, vassalage and later direct control.
- Explanation: Battlefield victory required political follow-through.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH

Hard MCQ 32

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

What did Chandawar in 1194 primarily disrupt?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	The Ghaznavid court at Ghazni.
B	The Chola navy.
C	The Seljuk state in Khurasan.
D	The Gahadavala coordinating centre under Jaichandra and access to the upper Ganga region.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: D - The Gahadavala coordinating centre under Jaichandra and access to the upper Ganga region.
- Explanation: It was a regional dynastic-political turning point.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH

Hard MCQ 33

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Why is Chandawar not the end of the conquest story?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	Forts, local chiefs, revenue networks and rebellions still had to be managed for decades.
B	Muizz al-Din immediately retired to Somnath.
C	The battle occurred before Tarain I.
D	No territory changed hands.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: A - Forts, local chiefs, revenue networks and rebellions still had to be managed for decades.
- Explanation: Conquest and consolidation are distinct.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH**Hard MCQ 34**

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

What was Aibak's central historical role before 1206?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	He wrote Kitab al-Hind.
B	He converted Ghurid victories into bases, garrisons, tribute arrangements and further campaigns.
C	He commanded Prithviraj at Tarain I.
D	He was the last Ghaznavid at Lahore.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: B - He converted Ghurid victories into bases, garrisons, tribute arrangements and further campaigns.
- Explanation: Delegated continuity mattered.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH

Hard MCQ 35

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Which is an example of the limit of distant occupation?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	Delhi was never occupied.
B	Lahore immediately returned to the Ghaznavids after 1186.
C	The Turks could not hold Anhilwara for long after taking it.
D	Bayana lay outside India.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: C - The Turks could not hold Anhilwara for long after taking it.
- Explanation: Operational success could exceed garrison capacity.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH

Hard MCQ 36

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

How should Bakhtiyar Khalji's eastern campaigns be framed?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	As the peaceful annexation of all eastern India.
B	As Mahmud's 1018 campaign.
C	As a naval conquest from Gujarat.
D	As rapid, delegated and disruptive thrusts that did not instantly produce uniform Bihar-Bengal control.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: D - As rapid, delegated and disruptive thrusts that did not instantly produce uniform Bihar-Bengal control.
- Explanation: Speed and surprise require a consolidation caveat.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH**Hard MCQ 37**

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Which statement on Buddhist monasteries is safest?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	Attacks on major Bihar monasteries were severe, but one commander cannot explain the whole long decline of Buddhism.
B	No monastery was attacked.
C	The attacks created Buddhism in Bengal.
D	Every monastery in India ended in one year.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: A - Attacks on major Bihar monasteries were severe, but one commander cannot explain the whole long decline of Buddhism.
- Explanation: Long-term institutional change is multi-causal.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH**Hard MCQ 38**

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Why did the Ghurids use vassal arrangements?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	They rejected all tribute.
B	They reduced immediate administrative burdens and used local authority while garrisons were limited.
C	They had no interest in territory.
D	Vassalage proves no conquest occurred.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: B - They reduced immediate administrative burdens and used local authority while garrisons were limited.
- Explanation: Accommodation and coercion often alternated.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH

Hard MCQ 39

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Which statement best describes the military comparison?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	Rajputs lacked horses entirely.
B	Turks possessed iron weapons unknown in India.
C	The key gap was an interacting system of mobility, command, reserves, finance and logistics, not courage or race.
D	One religious identity determined tactical skill.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: C - The key gap was an interacting system of mobility, command, reserves, finance and logistics, not courage or race.
- Explanation: Systemic comparison avoids essentialism.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH

Hard MCQ 40

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

What is the safest statement about elephants?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	They were always useless.
B	Only Ghurids used them.
C	They automatically caused defeat at every battle.
D	They could provide shock and stability but required coordinated cavalry and command.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: D - They could provide shock and stability but required coordinated cavalry and command.
- Explanation: Combined-arms use determines value.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH**Hard MCQ 41**

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Why were feudatory contingents a potential command problem?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	Separate leadership could hinder unified manoeuvre, reserves and re-concentration.
B	They supplied no soldiers.
C	They were all disloyal in every battle.
D	Turkish armies had no factionalism.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: A - Separate leadership could hinder unified manoeuvre, reserves and re-concentration.
- Explanation: A potential organisational cost is not a moral judgement.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH

Hard MCQ 42

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Which counter-example is essential against military determinism?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	Mahmud's death in Ghazni.
B	Prithviraj's victory at Tarain I.
C	Firdausi's poetry.
D	The building of Jam Minaret.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: B - Prithviraj's victory at Tarain I.
- Explanation: The same broad military cultures produced different outcomes.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH

Hard MCQ 43

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Why did Ghurids establish wider Gangetic rule than Ghaznavids?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	They had an entirely different religion.
B	Mahmud never controlled Punjab.
C	They combined a closer base, territorial objective, delegation and an institutional successor with favourable but contingent opportunities.
D	Rajput forces disappeared after 1030.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: C - They combined a closer base, territorial objective, delegation and an institutional successor with favourable but contingent opportunities.
- Explanation: Objective and organisation explain more than identity.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH**Hard MCQ 44**

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

What does post-1206 history add to the comparison?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	Muizz al-Din personally ruled Delhi until 1236.
B	The Ghaznavids returned under Balban.
C	No further consolidation was needed.
D	Endurance depended on Aibak and Iltutmish building an Indian-centred state after Ghurid fragmentation.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: D - Endurance depended on Aibak and Iltutmish building an Indian-centred state after Ghurid fragmentation.
- Explanation: A battle opening became durable only through later state formation.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH**Hard MCQ 45**

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Which consequence came earliest and most directly?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	Political-military disruption, tribute, loot and new garrisons in selected regions.
B	Uniform social transformation across India.
C	Immediate replacement of all village institutions.
D	The end of Persian culture.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: A - Political-military disruption, tribute, loot and new garrisons in selected regions.

- Explanation: Time horizons must be separated.

- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH

Hard MCQ 46

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

How should temple destruction be contextualised?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	It should be omitted from history.
B	State rivalry, wealth, symbolism and religious legitimisation can interact without denying violence.
C	It always had one identical cause.
D	Context proves no destruction occurred.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: B - State rivalry, wealth, symbolism and religious legitimisation can interact without denying violence.
- Explanation: Explanation is neither denial nor monocausal accusation.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH

Hard MCQ 47

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

What does the UNESCO Jam-Qutb linkage demonstrate?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	Jam and Qutb are the same monument.
B	Qutb Minar was built by Mahmud in 1025.
C	Ghurid architectural forms and ornament travelled into early Islamic architecture in India.
D	Architecture proves uniform political control.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: C - Ghurid architectural forms and ornament travelled into early Islamic architecture in India.
- Explanation: Influence is not identity.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH**Hard MCQ 48**

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Which historiographical synthesis is strongest?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	Adopt one communal narrative as total explanation.
B	Ignore chronicles completely.
C	Treat all later legends as eyewitness fact.
D	Combine source criticism, political economy, religious rhetoric, military systems, frontier geography and contingency.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: D - Combine source criticism, political economy, religious rhetoric, military systems, frontier geography and contingency.
- Explanation: The problem is multi-source and multi-causal.
- Why the distractors fail: each collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Hard conceptual MCQ

HIGH**Remedial MCQ 49**

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Which ruler is correctly matched?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	Mahmud - Ghaznavid ruler, 998-1030.
B	Muizz al-Din - founder of Ghaznavid dynasty in 963.
C	Aibak - ruler of Ghur in 1163.
D	Jayapala - Ghurid commander at Tarain II.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: A - Mahmud - Ghaznavid ruler, 998-1030.

- Explanation: Fix the ruler-dynasty distinction first.

- Remedial target: correct this error before returning to comparison and source questions.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Remedial MCQ

HIGH

Remedial MCQ 50

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Which date pair is correct?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	Tarain I 1192; Tarain II 1194.
B	Tarain I 1191; Tarain II 1192.
C	Tarain I 1178; Tarain II 1186.
D	Tarain I 1025; Tarain II 1030.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: B - Tarain I 1191; Tarain II 1192.
- Explanation: The sequence is Prithviraj victory then defeat.
- Remedial target: correct this error before returning to comparison and source questions.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Remedial MCQ

HIGH

Remedial MCQ 51

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Which statement on Somnath is correct?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	al-Utbi witnessed the raid.
B	The raid founded the Delhi Sultanate.
C	Mahmud raided it in 1025 and did not establish lasting Ghaznavid rule in Gujarat.
D	The site was never rebuilt or remembered again.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: C - Mahmud raided it in 1025 and did not establish lasting Ghaznavid rule in Gujarat.
- Explanation: Retain date, raid and non-annexation.
- Remedial target: correct this error before returning to comparison and source questions.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Remedial MCQ

HIGH**Remedial MCQ 52**

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Which is the correct source match?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	al-Utbi - Prithviraj's Sanskrit court poem.
B	Hasan Nizami - Ghaznavid chronicle ending before 1020.
C	Minhaj - eyewitness at Tarain I.
D	al-Biruni - comparative study of India.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: D - al-Biruni - comparative study of India.
- Explanation: Know genre and chronology.
- Remedial target: correct this error before returning to comparison and source questions.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Remedial MCQ

HIGH

Remedial MCQ 53

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

What follows from campaign-count variation?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	Use a conventional count cautiously and focus on secure campaigns.
B	Discard every campaign as fictional.
C	Treat seventeen as an official audited total.
D	Assume all operations were annexations.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: A - Use a conventional count cautiously and focus on secure campaigns.
- Explanation: Uncertain counting is not absence of campaigning.
- Remedial target: correct this error before returning to comparison and source questions.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Remedial MCQ

HIGH

Remedial MCQ 54

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Which is the best motive answer?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	Religion was always irrelevant.
B	Multiple motives operated, and their weight varied by campaign.
C	Only plunder mattered in Punjab.
D	Every temple attack had identical context.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: B - Multiple motives operated, and their weight varied by campaign.
- Explanation: Reject single-cause extremes.
- Remedial target: correct this error before returning to comparison and source questions.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Remedial MCQ

HIGH**Remedial MCQ 55**

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Why did the 1178 defeat matter?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	It ended Ghurid power permanently.
B	It occurred after Chandawar.
C	It pushed Muizz al-Din toward a Punjab-first strategy.
D	It made Gujarat a Ghurid province.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: C - It pushed Muizz al-Din toward a Punjab-first strategy.
- Explanation: Defeat and learning belong together.
- Remedial target: correct this error before returning to comparison and source questions.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Remedial MCQ

HIGH

Remedial MCQ 56

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Which statement on Tarain II is safest?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	Rajputs had no cavalry.
B	Jaichandra's romantic grievance is proven as the sole cause.
C	Ghurid victory was inevitable after 1178.
D	Mobility, command, reserves and preparation interacted; no one weapon explains the outcome.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: D - Mobility, command, reserves and preparation interacted; no one weapon explains the outcome.
- Explanation: Use a system explanation.
- Remedial target: correct this error before returning to comparison and source questions.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Remedial MCQ

HIGH

Remedial MCQ 57

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

What does conquest not automatically equal?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	Consolidation through garrisons, revenue, alliances and administration.
B	A battle.
C	A campaign route.
D	A chronicle.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: A - Consolidation through garrisons, revenue, alliances and administration.
- Explanation: The conceptual distinction is essential.
- Remedial target: correct this error before returning to comparison and source questions.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Remedial MCQ

HIGH**Remedial MCQ 58**

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Which statement on Aibak is correct?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	He led Mahmud's Somnath raid.
B	He managed and extended Ghurid conquests before becoming an independent ruler after 1206.
C	He wrote Kitab al-Hind.
D	He was defeated by Prithviraj at Tarain I as Ghurid sovereign.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: B - He managed and extended Ghurid conquests before becoming an independent ruler after 1206.
- Explanation: Aibak is commander/manager first, Sultan later.
- Remedial target: correct this error before returning to comparison and source questions.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Remedial MCQ

HIGH

Remedial MCQ 59

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

How should source silence be treated?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	As conclusive proof of no event.
B	As more reliable than archaeology in every case.
C	As a problem requiring explanation, not proof that an event did not matter.
D	As permission to invent missing details.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: C - As a problem requiring explanation, not proof that an event did not matter.
- Explanation: Absence is evidence only after preservation and genre are assessed.
- Remedial target: correct this error before returning to comparison and source questions.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Remedial MCQ

HIGH

Remedial MCQ 60

Prelims Solved
Practice

QUESTION

Which final verdict is most accurate?

OPTIONS

Option	Response
A	Tarain II instantly created rule over all India.
B	Mahmud and Muizz al-Din had identical objectives.
C	Rajput resistance ended permanently in 1192.
D	Ghurid victory opened a new political order, but uniform Sultanate rule emerged only through later consolidation.

SOLVED EXPLANATION

- Correct answer: D - Ghurid victory opened a new political order, but uniform Sultanate rule emerged only through later consolidation.
- Explanation: Keep the transition staged and contingent.
- Remedial target: correct this error before returning to comparison and source questions.

KEY RECALL

1. Apply chronology, source genre and conquest/consolidation distinctions before eliminating options.

ERROR CHECK

WRONG: Choose a familiar name or absolute statement without checking period and evidence.

CORRECT: Test each option against dynasty, date, mechanism and stated qualification.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The explanation converts the objective fact into an evidence-led analytical route.

PRACTICE TYPE

Remedial MCQ

HIGH**Mains 10M-1 - Frontier setting and Ghaznavid rise**GS-I Solved
Mains**QUESTION AND DIRECTIVE**

Explain how the Central Asian-Afghan political setting enabled the rise of the Ghaznavids on India's north-western frontier. (10 marks, 150 words)

EVIDENCE-LED MODEL ANSWER

- Direct thesis: Ghaznavid power arose from the intersection of Samanid fragmentation, Turkic military service, Persianate court culture and the strategic conversion of Ghazni into a road-linked frontier base.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: The Samanids employed Turkic military slaves and commanders; Alp-tigin established himself at Ghazni in 963.
- This shows how service office could become dynastic power, though military slaves were never automatically loyal.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Sabuktigin's wars and the c. 990-91 Shahi defeat brought Kabul-Jalalabad into the Ghazni sphere.
- Strategic depth shifted, but Shahi resistance continued under Jayapala and Anandapala.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Road improvement from Ghazni toward Kabul and Jalalabad supported intelligence, remounts and repeated campaigning.
- Geography became usable infrastructure, not an inevitable invasion funnel.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Persian language and Samanid-Iranian administrative culture shaped the Turkic court.
- The result was a Persianate military state, not an ethnically homogeneous army.
- Conclusion: Ghaznavid rise was therefore institutional and logistical as much as martial; the Punjab breach was created through a long frontier struggle rather than one sudden invasion.

ANSWER CHECKLIST

1. The answer begins with a direct thesis and answers the stated directive.
2. Named chronicles, sites, battles, coins or institutions are tied to analytical claims.
3. The conclusion is graded and does not overstate conquest or source certainty.

QUALITY CONTROL

WRONG: Narrate campaigns without answering how, why or how far.

CORRECT: Use evidence to prove mechanisms and include a limitation.

WHY THIS EARNS MARKS

It answers the enabling setting, uses three precise evidence chains, distinguishes corridor from inevitability and closes with a causal verdict proportional to 10 marks.

EVIDENCE PATTERN

Claim -> named evidence -> significance -> limit -> verdict.

HIGH**Mains 10M-2 - Mahmud's motives**GS-I Solved
Mains**QUESTION AND DIRECTIVE**

Mahmud of Ghazni's Indian campaigns cannot be explained by religious zeal alone. Explain. (10 marks, 150 words)

EVIDENCE-LED MODEL ANSWER

- Direct thesis: Religious rhetoric was politically important, but Mahmud's campaigns joined it to frontier security, dynastic legitimacy, revenue extraction and the financing of Central Asian wars.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: al-Utbi's panegyric and Mahmud's image as ghazi/but-shikan legitimised victory and mobilised followers.
- Court rhetoric, however, cannot reveal the whole strategic calculus.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: The long wars against Jayapala and Anandapala and the annexation of Punjab/Multan secured Ghazni's south-eastern frontier.
- This territorial aim differs from the non-annexing Mathura-Kanauj and Somnath raids.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Wealth from 1018 and 1025 supported reward networks, Ghazni's display and wars in Khurasan.
- Loot estimates are rhetorical, but the selection of rich political-temple centres is clear.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Hindu officers and Jat soldiers served Ghaznavid armies.
- This does not erase religious violence; it disproves a simple civilisational bloc model.
- Conclusion: Religion supplied a powerful idiom, while state security, resources and transregional competition structured Mahmud's repeated choices.

ANSWER CHECKLIST

1. The answer begins with a direct thesis and answers the stated directive.
2. Named chronicles, sites, battles, coins or institutions are tied to analytical claims.
3. The conclusion is graded and does not overstate conquest or source certainty.

QUALITY CONTROL

WRONG: Narrate campaigns without answering how, why or how far.

CORRECT: Use evidence to prove mechanisms and include a limitation.

WHY THIS EARNS MARKS

It preserves religious agency without monocausality, contrasts territorial and raiding objectives and uses four named evidence units in a concise structure.

EVIDENCE PATTERN

Claim -> named evidence -> significance -> limit -> verdict.

HIGH**Mains 10M-3 - Tarain comparison**GS-I Solved
Mains**QUESTION AND DIRECTIVE**

What explains the reversal between the First and Second Battles of Tarain? (10 marks, 150 words)

EVIDENCE-LED MODEL ANSWER

- Direct thesis: The reversal came from Ghurid learning, preparation and integrated manoeuvre, combined with the Chahamana failure to convert the 1191 victory into frontier recovery; it was not predetermined military superiority.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Prithviraj's immediate response to Tabarhinda produced a complete victory in 1191.
- This proves Rajput battlefield capacity, though the subsequent siege did not expel the Ghurids from Punjab.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Muizz al-Din returned after reorganising disgraced commanders and preparing a renewed army.
- The narrative of exact numbers is exaggerated, but institutional learning is visible.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Satish Chandra describes mounted archers harassing slower formations from several directions in 1192.
- Mobility and reserves mattered, though the account is not a modern battlefield survey.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Prithviraj's feudatory coalition had large resources but more fragmented command.
- Later Sanyogita romance cannot substitute for political analysis.
- Conclusion: Tarain II was a contingent victory created by adaptation, command and strategy after a real Ghurid defeat.

ANSWER CHECKLIST

1. The answer begins with a direct thesis and answers the stated directive.
2. Named chronicles, sites, battles, coins or institutions are tied to analytical claims.
3. The conclusion is graded and does not overstate conquest or source certainty.

QUALITY CONTROL

WRONG: Narrate campaigns without answering how, why or how far.

CORRECT: Use evidence to prove mechanisms and include a limitation.

WHY THIS EARNS MARKS

It directly compares both battles, uses 1191 as counter-evidence, explains mechanisms and rejects numbers, betrayal and weapon monocausality.

EVIDENCE PATTERN

Claim -> named evidence -> significance -> limit -> verdict.

HIGH**Mains 15M-1 - Somnath source criticism and memory**GS-I Solved
Mains**QUESTION AND DIRECTIVE**

Discuss the Somnath raid through source criticism and explain why its later memory cannot be treated as a simple mirror of 1025. (15 marks, 250 words)

EVIDENCE-LED MODEL ANSWER

- Direct thesis: The 1025 Somnath raid was a major act of plunder, iconoclasm and royal display, but its reconstruction requires separating early reports, later Persian amplification, local records, material phases and modern political memory.
- Event and motive: Somnath joined temple wealth, pilgrimage, port-region commerce and royal symbolism.
- Mahmud's return without annexing Gujarat supports a high-prestige raid rather than a durable provincial project.
- This does not reduce the violence to economics alone because ghazi and image-breaking rhetoric carried political-religious value.
- Source chronology: al-Utbi is crucial for Mahmud's earlier ideology but his chronicle ends before Somnath. al-Biruni supplies an early learned description, while later Persian histories often elaborate victory and destruction.
- Chronological distance and panegyric borrowing require corroboration.
- Local and material evidence: Sanskrit, Jain and epigraphic traditions illuminate rebuilding, patronage and different memory priorities.
- Their silence or brevity cannot prove indifference, because donation and genealogy records were not trauma chronicles and survive selectively.
- Later memory: Colonial retrieval, nationalist reconstruction and communal politics transformed Somnath into a symbol of civilisational humiliation or recovery.
- Romila Thapar's multi-voice approach shows that event and retrospective meaning belong to distinct analytical layers.
- Qualification: Exact defender numbers, loot totals, speeches and dramatic image-ransom stories should be excluded unless securely corroborated.
- Conclusion: Somnath is historically important precisely because it combines a recoverable raid with changing political memories; source criticism protects both facts and complexity.

ANSWER CHECKLIST

1. The answer begins with a direct thesis and answers the stated directive.
2. Named chronicles, sites, battles, coins or institutions are tied to analytical claims.
3. The conclusion is graded and does not overstate conquest or source certainty.

QUALITY CONTROL

WRONG: Narrate campaigns without answering how, why or how far.

CORRECT: Use evidence to prove mechanisms and include a limitation.

WHY THIS EARNS MARKS

It answers both event and memory, ranks five evidence layers, names al-Utbi/al-Biruni/Thapar, states non-annexation and excludes embellished detail.

EVIDENCE PATTERN

Claim -> named evidence -> significance -> limit -> verdict.

HIGH**Mains 15M-2 - Military systems without essentialism**GS-I Solved
Mains**QUESTION AND DIRECTIVE**

Compare Ghurid and Rajput military systems and assess the causes of Ghurid success without civilisational stereotypes. (15 marks, 250 words)

EVIDENCE-LED MODEL ANSWER

- Direct thesis: Ghurid success reflected an interacting military-fiscal system - mobility, mounted archery, reserves, command, intelligence and bases - while Rajput armies possessed courage, cavalry, elephants and large resources but faced particular coordination problems.
- Mobility and fire: At Tarain II, mounted archers reportedly harassed slower Chahamana formations from several directions.
- This demonstrates manoeuvre and distance fighting; it does not prove Rajputs lacked bows or horses.
- Command and finance: Mamluk/amirs trained in service and revenue assignments helped rulers maintain concentrated forces.
- Feudatory Rajput contingents mobilised major resources and local knowledge, but separate command could impede reserves and rapid re-concentration.
- Turkish polities also suffered factionalism, so the contrast is relative.
- Combined arms: Elephants supplied shock and stability when coordinated with cavalry.
- They became vulnerable under harassment or loss of control; they were not inherently obsolete.
- Iron stirrups and imported horses were known in India, refuting a secret-weapon explanation.
- Logistics and bases: Ghazni-Kabul roads and, later, Lahore/Punjab shortened Ghurid lines.
- Yet Gujarat 1178, Kashmir 1015 and Bakhtiyar's failed eastern expedition show that supply and terrain could reverse mobile forces.
- Contingency and politics: Tarain I proves Indian forces could win.
- Prithviraj's political isolation and failure to recover Punjab after 1191 increased risk but should not be converted into timeless 'Rajput disunity.'
- Conclusion: The Ghurid advantage was organisational and situational, not racial, religious or mechanically technological.

ANSWER CHECKLIST

1. The answer begins with a direct thesis and answers the stated directive.
2. Named chronicles, sites, battles, coins or institutions are tied to analytical claims.
3. The conclusion is graded and does not overstate conquest or source certainty.

QUALITY CONTROL

WRONG: Narrate campaigns without answering how, why or how far.

CORRECT: Use evidence to prove mechanisms and include a limitation.

WHY THIS EARNS MARKS

It covers weapons, command, finance, logistics, politics and counter-evidence, with qualifications in every paragraph and a clear assessed verdict.

EVIDENCE PATTERN

Claim -> named evidence -> significance -> limit -> verdict.

HIGH**Mains 15M-3 - Conquest versus consolidation**GS-I Solved
Mains**QUESTION AND DIRECTIVE**

Distinguish conquest from consolidation in the Ghurid expansion, with special reference to Aibak and the eastern campaigns. (15 marks, 250 words)

EVIDENCE-LED MODEL ANSWER

- Direct thesis: Tarain and Chandawar broke major regional coordinating centres, but durable rule required delegated occupation, forts, tribute, local accommodation and repeated suppression; conquest therefore preceded rather than completed consolidation.
- Battlefield opening: Tarain II opened Delhi-Ajmer and Chandawar disrupted Gahadavala power.
- Their significance was strategic, but neither battle supplied administrators, revenue information or secure countryside control.
- Aibak's mechanism: Muizz al-Din left Qutb al-Din Aibak to occupy Delhi, manage Ajmer rebellions and extend into the doab.
- Hansi, Samana, Bayana and Gwalior illustrate a fort-and-route strategy.
- A fort, however, did not guarantee surrounding agrarian obedience.
- Accommodation: Hasan Nizami and coin evidence cited by Satish Chandra suggest initial subordinate arrangements with Tomar/Chahamana authority.
- Such vassalage economised scarce manpower; rebellion could produce direct occupation.
- Coin reading and sequence remain debated.
- Distance limit: A Ghurid force took Anhilwara but could not retain it.
- This proves operational reach exceeded garrison capacity.
- Eastern bound: Bakhtiyar Khalji's Bihar raids and Nadia-Lakhnauti thrust demonstrate surprise and delegated initiative.
- They damaged major monasteries and displaced the Sena court from Nadia, but Sena successors and regional resistance continued; one attack did not create uniform Bengal rule or single-handedly end Buddhism.
- Conclusion: Consolidation was a negotiated, violent and decades-long process completed only partly under the Ghurids and carried forward by the Delhi Sultanate.

ANSWER CHECKLIST

1. The answer begins with a direct thesis and answers the stated directive.
2. Named chronicles, sites, battles, coins or institutions are tied to analytical claims.
3. The conclusion is graded and does not overstate conquest or source certainty.

QUALITY CONTROL

WRONG: Narrate campaigns without answering how, why or how far.

CORRECT: Use evidence to prove mechanisms and include a limitation.

WHY THIS EARNS MARKS

It defines both concepts, uses Aibak, forts, vassalage, Anhilwara and Bakhtiyar as evidence, and maintains the Bihar-Bengal source caution.

EVIDENCE PATTERN

Claim -> named evidence -> significance -> limit -> verdict.

HIGH**Mains 20M-1 - Why Ghurid rule became wider and more durable**GS-I Solved
Mains**QUESTION AND DIRECTIVE**

Why did the Ghurids establish wider and more durable rule in the Gangetic plain than the Ghaznavids? Analyse. (20 marks, 300 words)

EVIDENCE-LED MODEL ANSWER

- Direct thesis: The contrast arose from different strategic objectives, inherited bases, timing, delegation and institutional aftermath.
- It cannot be reduced to the personal ability of Mahmud and Muizz al-Din or to a timeless military superiority.
- Different objectives: Mahmud combined frontier security and Punjab annexation with repeated deep raids whose revenue, prestige and religious legitimisation served a Central Asian empire.
- Mathura-Kanauj in 1018 and Somnath in 1025 produced reach without Gangetic administration.
- Muizz al-Din, by contrast, repeatedly sought tribute, forts and territorial succession after Punjab.
- Base and route: Mahmud's defeat of the Shahis and control of Punjab breached the frontier.
- The Ghurids inherited this achievement, removed Khusrau Malik from Lahore in 1186 and later made Delhi an inland operational base.
- This shortened lines to the doab.
- Learning and timing: Muizz al-Din lost in Gujarat in 1178 and at Tarain in 1191, then shifted route and preparation.
- The late-twelfth-century rivalry among Chauhans and Gahadavalas created opportunities, but Tarain I proves the outcome was not inevitable.
- Delegation: Aibak continuously managed Delhi, Ajmer, forts and doab expansion while Muizz al-Din returned west.
- Bakhtiyar and other commanders extended initiative eastward.
- This commander network converted royal campaigns into repeated occupation.
- Political mechanisms: Vassal arrangements, tribute, garrisons and use of existing revenue channels economised manpower.
- The failure to hold Anhilwara and long resistance show their limits.

- Institutional succession: After 1206, the Ghurid empire fragmented, but Aibak and Iltutmish built an Indian-centred Sultanate.
- No comparable Ghaznavid Gangetic successor had followed Mahmud.
- Qualification: Mahmud was often the more consistently successful general, while Ghurid consolidation remained uneven and took decades.
- Conclusion: Ghaznavid Punjab was the strategic foundation; Ghurid objectives, delegation and post-conquest institutions converted that foundation into a more durable north Indian state.

ANSWER CHECKLIST

1. The answer begins with a direct thesis and answers the stated directive.
2. Named chronicles, sites, battles, coins or institutions are tied to analytical claims.
3. The conclusion is graded and does not overstate conquest or source certainty.

QUALITY CONTROL

WRONG: Narrate campaigns without answering how, why or how far.

CORRECT: Use evidence to prove mechanisms and include a limitation.

WHY THIS EARNS MARKS

It ranks causes across objective, base, timing, learning, delegation and succession, compares precise campaigns and ends with a graded rather than triumphalist verdict.

EVIDENCE PATTERN

Claim -> named evidence -> significance -> limit -> verdict.

HIGH**Mains 20M-2 - Consequences and limits**GS-I Solved
Mains**QUESTION AND DIRECTIVE**

Assess the political, social, economic and cultural consequences of the Ghaznavid-Ghurid incursions and conquests in north India. (20 marks, 300 words)

EVIDENCE-LED MODEL ANSWER

- Direct thesis: The most immediate consequences were political-military disruption and fiscal transfer; wider social and cultural changes emerged unevenly through Punjab-Lahore settlement, Persianate networks, delegated administration and the later Sultanate.
- Political: Shahi defeat and Ghaznavid Punjab removed strategic depth; Tarain and Chandawar broke Chahamana and Gahadavala coordinating centres.
- Delhi became a Ghurid base.
- Yet Rajput successor centres, forts and local chiefs persisted, and consolidation took decades.
- Military: Mobile cavalry, mounted archery, integrated reserves and route-garrison strategy gained importance.
- Indian forces did not simply disappear; Tarain I and regional resistance show adaptation and continued capacity.
- Economic: Mathura-Kanauj, Somnath, Asni/Banaras and other centres suffered plunder or tribute claims, transferring portable wealth to conquering networks.
- Punjab also yielded recurring revenue and coin circulation.
- Effects were regionally unequal; agrarian and commercial life continued beyond attacked nodes.
- Social: New military-service groups, migrants, scholars and merchants interacted with local chiefs, warriors, artisans and revenue intermediaries.

- Hindu commanders and Jat soldiers in Ghaznavid service reveal composite armies.
- Chronicle bias, however, leaves non-elite experience obscure.
- Religious institutions: Selected wealthy temples and Bihar monasteries suffered attack for overlapping political, fiscal and ideological reasons.
- Contextualisation does not deny destruction, while one raid cannot explain all religious change.
- Cultural: Ghazni and Lahore transmitted Persian language, literature and court practice; Firdausi and al-Biruni represent different dimensions of that world.
- UNESCO's Jam-Qutb comparison illustrates architectural transmission, but Indian craftsmen, materials and motifs transformed the forms.
- State transition: Ghurid victories created an opening, not a completed Sultanate.
- Post-1206 rulers institutionalised the new order.
- Conclusion: The period was simultaneously coercive, extractive and connective; its consequences were profound but staged, negotiated and regionally varied.

ANSWER CHECKLIST

1. The answer begins with a direct thesis and answers the stated directive.
2. Named chronicles, sites, battles, coins or institutions are tied to analytical claims.
3. The conclusion is graded and does not overstate conquest or source certainty.

QUALITY CONTROL

WRONG: Narrate campaigns without answering how, why or how far.

CORRECT: Use evidence to prove mechanisms and include a limitation.

WHY THIS EARNS MARKS

It answers every dimension, uses more than eight named evidence clusters, preserves violence and interaction, and repeatedly distinguishes immediate impact from long-term transition.

EVIDENCE PATTERN

Claim -> named evidence -> significance -> limit -> verdict.

HIGH**Mains 20M-3 - Sources and historiography**GS-I Solved
Mains**QUESTION AND DIRECTIVE**

Evaluate the sources and historiographical approaches used to reconstruct the Ghaznavid and Ghurid invasions of India. (20 marks, 300 words)

EVIDENCE-LED MODEL ANSWER

- Direct thesis: Reconstruction depends on court chronicles, comparative scholarship, Indic literary-epigraphic traditions and material evidence, each illuminating a different layer and each requiring scrutiny of date, genre, patronage and silence.
- Ghaznavid chronicles: al-Utbi's Kitab al-Yamini offers early campaign and legitimacy language but is ornate panegyric with weak Indian geography and ends before Somnath.
- Gardizi is more concise but court-linked and derivative in places.
- Bayhaqi gives unusually rich chancery and fiscal politics, chiefly for Masud's era and through a fragmentary elite archive.
- Al-Biruni: Kitab al-Hind contributes Sanskrit-based comparison in religion, astronomy and society.
- Its analytical independence is exceptional, yet learned Brahmanical interlocutors and north-western location narrow social reach.

- Ghurid-Delhi sources: Hasan Nizami provides an early conquest narrative shaped by Aibak's court and literary display.
- Minhaj's Tabaqat-i Nasiri preserves Ghurid genealogy and early Sultanate sequence but was completed c. 1260 under Delhi patronage.
- Modern UPenn work shows the value of reading it against the grain for Ghur's local society.
- Indic sources: Prithviraja Vijaya and Chahamana inscriptions provide royal self-representation; Prithviraj Raso and later epics reveal memory rather than eyewitness fact.
- Silence cannot be made proof of no event.
- Material archive: coins linked to negotiated authority, Ghazni and Jam monuments, Qutb inscriptions and fort landscapes can corroborate titles, patronage and occupation.
- Attribution, reuse, survival and circulation limits remain.
- Historiography: Colonial writing civilisationalised dynastic rupture; nationalist work recovered agency but could romanticise heroes; communal readings absolutised religion; materialist and military studies restored revenue, organisation and logistics; Persianate and memory studies highlight connection and archive construction.
- Conclusion: The strongest account triangulates sources and retains both violence and contingency.
- It neither repeats court victory rhetoric nor dissolves events into scepticism.

ANSWER CHECKLIST

1. The answer begins with a direct thesis and answers the stated directive.
2. Named chronicles, sites, battles, coins or institutions are tied to analytical claims.
3. The conclusion is graded and does not overstate conquest or source certainty.

QUALITY CONTROL

WRONG: Narrate campaigns without answering how, why or how far.

CORRECT: Use evidence to prove mechanisms and include a limitation.

WHY THIS EARNS MARKS

It evaluates seven named source clusters and five historiographical approaches, states what each proves and limits, and concludes with a defensible method.

EVIDENCE PATTERN

Claim -> named evidence -> significance -> limit -> verdict.